Tips for Moderating Usability Tests

The first few times you moderate a usability test it can be an overwhelming experience. You need to keep track of a lot of things at once and your participants might not behave exactly as you expected—they're human, after all!

Test moderation can be especially difficult if your participants find the think-aloud method awkward, or if the product you test has a lot of usability issues. You can use the tips below to help you handle these difficult situations:

Problem	Solution
The participant struggles a lot with your product and can't figure out how to move forward with the test task.	It's important not to over-moderate so let participants struggle for a bit longer than you might find comfortable. If they give up, ask them to move on to the next task.
The participant is silent while they solve your tasks.	Politely ask the participant to "remember to think out loud so I can follow along".

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Problem	Solution
The participant finds the think-aloud method awkward and says very little.	Follow up everything they say with “okay”, “uh-huh” and similar phrases to encourage them to keep talking out loud.
The participant feels insecure and asks if they are doing a good job.	Say things like “there are no right or wrong answers” or “you helped us identify what we were looking for” to encourage them.
The participant waits for your permission before they move on to the next task.	Remind the participant to move at their own pace during the test.
The participant mumbles or doesn’t speak clearly enough.	Politely ask the participant to speak louder and repeat what they say if needed.
The participant asks questions about how the product works.	Instead of answering, ask “reverse questions” like: Is this what you expect to find there?
The participant asks for your help in order to move forward.	Politely ask them to try a bit more. If they still find the task impossible, ask them to move on to the next task and tell them you’ll be happy to explain at the end of the test.

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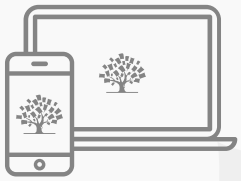

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